ANI



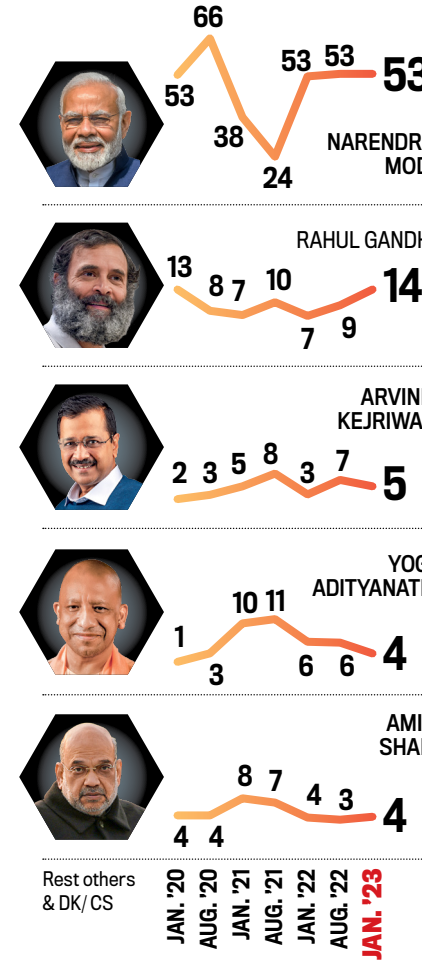
IN THE NET Cash seized by ED officials from an aide of West Bengal minister Partha Chatterjee, Jul. 28, 2022

to implement bold and innovative solutions to tackle problems. The surgical strikes he ordered against Pakistan after the Uri terror attack in 2016 and the air strikes after the Pulwama bomb blasts in 2019 continue to attract high approval ratings. Even his government's handling of the Chinese intrusions on the LAC, which the Congress has severely criticised him for, are perceived as satisfactory. Initiatives like demonetisation may have backfired, but they have not clouded the general perception that the intention behind them was well-meaning.

While Modi and his government have much to cheer about, they must realise that victory is far from certain in their second innings. The majority that the January 2023 MOTN gives them is increasingly vulnerable. The BJP's gains in this year's survey have been mainly from four states—Assam, Telangana, West Bengal and UP—where it is gaining 13 seats in all. However, in West Bengal, the BJP's tally could drop from the 20 seats (out of 42) it is projected to get—if Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee becomes a prime ministerial contender and invokes Bengali pride. Something similar could happen in Telangana if Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao throws his hat in the prime ministerial ring, and the BJP does not get the six seats (out of the state's 17 constituencies) it is currently projected to win. In Uttar Pradesh, too, winning 70 out of the 80 seats could become tough if a resurgent Akhilesh Yadav boosts the Samajwadi Party's tally as he did in the party's performance in the 2022 state assembly polls.

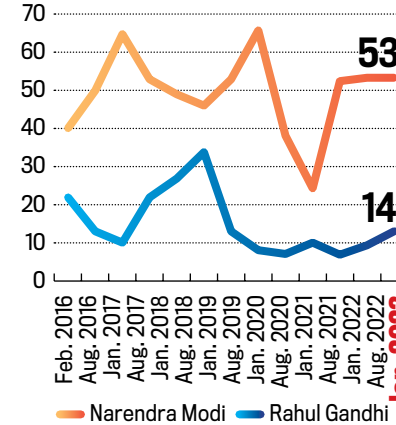
Modi and the BJP could also run into trouble in two other large states—Maharashtra (48 seats) and Bihar (40). In Maharashtra, the BJP may currently have the upper hand after joining hands with the rebel faction of the Shiv Sena led by Chief Minister Eknath Shinde to run the government. But if the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA), which includes the Uddhav Thackeray faction of the Sena, the Nationalist

Q WHO IS BEST SUITED TO BE THE NEXT PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA?



NARENDRA MODI VS RAHUL GANDHI

How the MOTN surveys reflected the public mood on the choice of prime ministerial candidate between the leaders of the two national parties



All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say